arrival and departure point for trains connecting southern and central Tamil Nadu and Kerala. With Mughal-style architecture, including semicircular domes and carvings, the spacious station resembles a palace. Built between 1905 and 1908 with fine granite stones, ornamental brackets, dripstones and friezes, this station is a strong link to the history and origin of the railways in India. It even has a few iron pillars embossed with the words ‘Made in Porto Novo’, Porto Novo being one of India’s oldest ironworks plants.

It is interesting to note that Porto Novo, or Parangipettai, located on the north bank of the Vellar river, on the Coromandel coast, has a lot more than its iron and steel history to boast about. It is about 30 km from Cuddalore district in Tamil Nadu. Porto Novo was not only ground zero for the first iron and steel industry plant in India in the 1830s, but also possibly the starting point for the country’s steam railways. [2] The small plant of Porto Novo Iron Company [3] on the Madras coast, started by Josiah Marshall Heath in 1830, produced pig iron at the rate of 40 tonnes a week. [4] This was the first notable effort of this magnitude in India. Traces of this iconic firm are imprinted on the pillars of Chennai Egmore station. I was standing there looking for these historical markers.

Walking up and down the station for hours amidst a clutter of passengers rushing with their luggage, continuous announcements in three languages about train arrivals and departures, my eyes were fixed on those pillars. After much strain, I did spot faint markings, but they were illegible, thickly painted over and almost disappearing.

The two sets of twenty-plus tall iron pillars supporting the platform’s main arched roof were made of cast iron. There were markings on two of the old pillars—to be precise, on the sixth and the eleventh ones—on one of the platforms. But they were too high up, faint and buried under numerous layers of thick paint, and entangled wires of the station’s Wi-Fi routers. I counted the pillars again, made mental notes, and decided to leave after four hours. After all, I had to return to Mumbai.

EMPTY-HANDED, BUT NOT COMPLETELY SO

Even though the physical links to India’s rail history are being wiped out slowly as generations pass, the stories of how these lines got built and are still functioning perfectly today are fascinating. Porto Novo was one of the